

MSc Research Project/Internship/ Practicum

Literature Review

Literature Review – Critique

- **The process of critical evaluation lies at the heart of what we might call knowledge creation. When researchers submit research papers to peer-reviewed journals in their fields, their papers are reviewed anonymously by other researchers, who critically assess each study in terms of**
 - The study's contribution to knowledge, theory, or practice in a field
 - The study's research design and methodology
 - The study's findings, in particular, how they are presented and interpreted
 - The researcher's conclusions
 - The writing quality, clarity, and style, and the organization of the information presented
- **If you are asked to write a critique of a research article, you should focus on these issues. You will also need to consider where and when the article was published and who wrote it.**

Literature Review – Guidelines for Writing a Critique

- **Begin your critique by identifying**
 - the article's title,
 - author(s),
 - date of publication
 - Name of the journal (or conference)
 - other publications in which it appeared.
- **You should also briefly describe the purpose and nature of the study, the methods used and the main results. You should also comment on any limitations in the approach.**
- **If the paper was not published in a peer-reviewed journal, consider the credibility of the publication in which it appeared and the credentials (and possible biases) of the researchers.**

Literature Review – Guidelines for Writing a Critique

- Use headings to structure your critique. In each section, provide enough descriptive information so that your review will be clear to a reader who may not have read the study.
- Aim for an objective, balanced, and well supported critique.
Polit and Beck (2008) advise:
 - Balance your analysis to include both strengths and weakness
 - Justify your criticism by giving examples of the study's weaknesses and strengths
- Conclude your analysis by briefly summing up the **strengths** and **weaknesses** of the study and by assessing its contribution to the advancement of knowledge, theory, or practice.
- Consider suggesting research directions and methodological considerations for future researchers

Literature Review – Guidelines for Writing a Critique

- **Use past or present tense consistently whenever you refer to completed research. Check if your discipline has a preference.**
- **Use a standard citation style (e.g., IEEE, HARVARD, APA, MLA, or Chicago/Turabian) to format references in your critique and be sure to cite page numbers for all quoted passages.**

Elements of a Research Critique and Questions to Consider Writing a Critique

Table 1. Elements of a Research Critique and Questions to Consider in Writing a Critique

Elements of a research critique	Questions to ask/Information to include
Identifying information to include	Where and when was the article published? Who wrote the article? What was the purpose of the study? What was the nature of the study (e.g., a case study, ethnography, a content analysis, or an experimental study)? What is the analytical approach or theoretical framework (e.g., a feminist analysis, a critical analysis, an application of a specific theoretical model)?
Research design and methodology ⁴	How does the method reflect or augment other studies of the same topic? What makes this method feasible? How realistic is it? Why will this method produce data that will answer the research question? How does the method address questions of validity? How does the researcher overcome the limitations of the method? Are there large limitations or minor ones? How will these limitations affect your ability to use this data to answer your research question? Was the research conducted ethically and following tri-council guidelines?
Interpretation of findings	Did the researcher find a correlation (relationship) or a cause? Are there alternative interpretations of the findings? How "generalizable" are the findings? Can the findings be applied to other populations or situations?
Writing quality, clarity, & style, and the organization of information	Does the source reflect the genre of the source's discipline(s)? Does the source offer sufficient detail? Are there gaps in the description or places with unnecessary description? Does the source present the information logically? Do the sources present an objective viewpoint? Does the author seem to have a bias or blind spot?
The value of the study	Is the research problem significant? What contribution does the study make to the advancement of knowledge, theory, or practice?

Literature Review (1)



- You are expected to provide a critical/analytic overview of the significant literature published on your topic.
- Please note: If your target audience knows more than you do, your purpose is to demonstrate familiarity, expertise, and intelligence with the topic.
- In your review of literature, you are expected to do the following:
 - Place one's original work in the context of existing literature.
 - Interpret the major issues surrounding your topic.
 - Describe the relationship of each work to the others under consideration.
 - Identify new ways to interpret and shed light on any gaps in previous research.
 - Resolve conflicts among seemingly contradictory previous studies.
 - Determine which literature makes a significant contribution to the understanding of your topic.
 - Point the way to further research on your topic.

Literature Review (2)



- Use **focused searches**. When you find a relevant paper follow the references in that paper to find other relevant papers.
- If the paper is important, then describe it in a paragraph in the literature review;
 - One sentence on what the **approach** was
 - One sentence on what the **method** used was
 - One sentence on what the **results** were
- **Comment on the strength and weakness/limitation of work in each reviewed papers. Strengths are good practice and something you should aim to emulate, weakness/limitations provide an opportunity for you to improve on or extend their work.**
- Check the future work section of each paper, it may provide you with ideas for your own work.

Literature Review (3)



- **There will be many papers that are not as important. These can be grouped together as a type of an approach.**
- **An important paper has a lot of citations and was written by researchers that are famous in the field. Important papers set the trend in the field.**
- **Less important papers have a minor contribution to the research field**
- **The literature review should end in a paragraph that summarises the findings from the state of the art, why the previous solution are not adequate and justifies the need for your research question:**
 - e.g. In conclusion, this problem is not solved because A solution that addresses this problem is required. This research proposes....

Literature Review (4)



- **Consider the following when assessing whether to include each work in your review of literature:**
 - **Qualifications:** What are the author's credentials to make the judgments he or she has made?
 - **Neutrality:** Is the author's perspective even-handed or biased?
 - **Credibility:** Which of the author's theses are convincing and why?
 - **Worth:** Do the author's conclusions add to the value of your own?
 - **Quality of Paper:** Is it a reputable Journal mentioned in Scopus/Are the authors findings supported in the evaluation
- **Please note your transitions between ideas analyze, synthesize, and assess these outside perspectives, and do not simply summarize or translate them**
- **Your attitude towards works that you present, either in support or against your topic, through the use of reporting verbs which allow the writer to convey clearly whether the claims in the outside work are to be taken as accepted or not.**